RUSSIAN TROOPS

Peasant conscripts formed the majority of the Russian army, with an admixture of workers from the major cities. Mobilization went very smoothly, but badly-led Russian forces suffered a catastrophic defeat at Tannenberg in late August 1914. From then on the Russians were beaten whenever they fought the Germans, although they sometimes inflicted defeats on the Austrians and the Turks. Discontent grew as lives were thrown away in futile offensives and conditions at the fronts worsened. Soldiers resented those exempted from conscription who made money out of the booming wartime economy and many also hated their arrogant and incompetent officers. In March 1917 soldiers in reserve units helped overthrow the Tsarist regime. Soldiers' committees (or "soviets") were set up and unpopular officers were ejected by their men. The new Provisional Government called on soldiers to continue to resist "the bayonets of conquerors", but the offensive of June 1917 revealed the limited appeal of continued fighting. It petered out and there were mass desertions. Nothing could stop the army's dissolution as peasant soldiers laid down their rifles and went home to join in land seizures. Some 1.8 million Russian troops had died in the war.



PAPAKHA SHEEPSKIN HAT

Badge in Romanov colours



Russian uniform
The khaki tunic, introduced in 1907, was worn with more traditional items of clothing, such as the Cossack papakha.



MOSIN-NAGANT RIFLE

> "WHAT'S THE USE OF US PEASANTS GETTING LAND IF I AM KILLED AND GET NO LAND?"
>
> **RUSSIAN PEASANT SOLDIER**, MAY 1917

ITALIAN TROOPS



Bersaglieri hat
The Bersaglieri, a crack rifle corps, wore distinctive plumed hats on parade.

Italy's belated declaration of war on Austria-Hungary in May 1915, motivated by territorial ambitions, was unpopular with much of the population. Having been unified only half a century earlier, Italy had built up only limited patriotic sentiment, and conscripts from Sicily and the south generally viewed the north of Italy as a foreign posting. The Alpine front to which Italian soldiers were sent was harsh and forbidding terrain. Weather conditions were often appalling and assaults on Alpine ridges, even if successful, only revealed another ridge behind to be taken. Only the elite Alpini had any special skills for coping with mountain warfare. Front-line troops often went short of food, clothing, and medical services. Soldiers were routinely mistreated by their officers.

The saving grace for the Italians was that the Austro-Hungarians were generally in a similar plight to themselves. The transfer of German forces to the Italian front precipitated disaster for Italy at Caporetto in October 1917. Demoralized, riddled with pacifist and defeatist sentiment, influenced by left-wing revolutionary ideas, and exhausted by too many costly offensives, Italian soldiers quit the battlefield almost as soon as the fighting began and fled as far and fast as they could. A defensive line was stabilized on the Piave River in winter 1917. After a period cautiously devoted to the restoration of morale, the Italians ended the war on the offensive, led by new assault troops, the Arditi. But overall the Italian soldier's experience of the war was disillusioning in the extreme. Almost half a million Italians died in the conflict.



Mountain trenches
Repeated Italian attempts to break through the Austrian lines failed despite heavy bombardments and vicious hand-to-hand fighting.

ID TAGS



FOLDING SHOVEL